

idea of how the registry is organised, and where you are likely to find the setting you want to change. Once you know that you will be able to navigate through the registry with much greater ease while looking for the setting you want to change.

- **HKEY_LOCAL_MACHINE**

Abbreviated as HKLM. According to its description in Microsoft TechNet: The HKEY_LOCAL_MACHINE subtree contains information about the local computer system, including hardware and operating system data, such as bus type, system memory, device drivers, and startup control parameters. The Software subkey in this key contains the bulk of the system-wide settings for applications installed in Windows. The settings in this section are usually arranged as Company/Product/Version as those are Microsoft's guidelines. Settings for Microsoft's own applications will thus be found in HKLM/Software/Microsoft, with setting for Windows itself under Windows.

- **HKEY_USERS**

This key contains user configuration keys for each user. It has one subkey for each user which is named after the user's security ID. For an explanation of what is contained in the subkeys read on for HKEY_CURRENT_USER.

- **HKEY_CURRENT_USER**

Abbreviated as HKCU. According to its description in Microsoft TechNet: The HKEY_CURRENT_USER subtree contains the user profile for the user who is currently logged on to the computer. The user profile includes environment variables, personal program groups, desktop settings, network connections, printers, and application preferences. The data in the user profile is similar to the data stored in the Win.ini file in Windows 3. x.

The HKEY_CURRENT_USER subtree does not contain any data. It just stores a pointer to the content of the HKEY_USERS\ Security ID (SID) of current user subkey. Therefore, the content of that subkey also appear in HKEY_CURRENT_USER, and it can be viewed and changed in either location. This subtree provides easier access to the data.

A new HKEY_CURRENT_USER subtree is created each time a user logs on. The data for the subtree comes from the profile of the current user. If no profile is available, the subtree is built from the user profile settings established for a default user, which are stored in System drive \ Documents and Settings\Default User (WINNT)\Ntuser.dat. While HKEY_LOCAL_MACHINE contains settings applicable machine-wide, this registry location is applicable only to the current user. As such it contains entries similar to HKEY_LOCAL_MACHINE.